



**BLESSED:** The Alphonsa chapel where Sr Alphonsa (below) is buried

Kottayam, Anna Muttathupadath became a nun when she was 18 and was christened Sister Alphonsa. Until her death in 1946 at the age of 36 after 16 years of illness, she was largely unknown outside her village. A number of miracles attributed to her started coming to light after her death which were formally examined first by Indian church authorities and then by Vatican's various committees, papal courts and medical panels. Pope John Paul II declared her the Blessed Servant of God in 1985 following his approval of a miracle attributed to her, related to the healing of a young boy's twisted feet after his family prayed at her tomb in at the Alphonsa Chapel at Bharananganam in Kottayam.

by M.G. Radhakrishnan

## The Making of a Saint

**THIRUVANANTHAPURAM** It was a moment of celebration in the 2,000-year-long history of Indian Christians. On March 1, the Holy See at the Vatican, the global headquarters of the Roman Catholic Church, formally fixed the date for canonising Sister Alphonsa of Kottayam. The nun who died half-a-century ago has become the first Indian woman and second Indian to be bestowed sainthood. The professed

Sister Alphonsa will be formally known as Saint Alphonsa of Immaculate Conception after canonisation on October 12 by Pope Benedict XVI at a function in St Peter's Basilica in the Vatican. The 'blessed' sister is among the four names finalised by the Pope to be inscribed into the roll of saints.

The only other Indian to be canonised was St Gonzalo Garcia, a 16th-century Jesuit priest



from Mumbai, in 1862. Sister Alphonsa's sainthood is the first universal recognition for the Kerala-based Syro-Malabar Church—India's largest Catholic church—to which the sister belonged.

Born in an ordinary family in Kudamaloor in

## THE BUZZ OF THE WEEK

A security lapse that led to Defence Minister A.K. Antony's motorcade heading the wrong way on a recent visit to Kerala has come in handy for the Opposition that wants to know how safe the country's security is in this Government's hands.

### VOICES



"You (the MPs) are working overtime to finish democracy. With great sorrow, sadness and resentment, I am forced to adjourn the House again and again."

Somnath Chatterjee, Lok Sabha Speaker

"There are 20 Kubers (god of wealth) on one side and 30 crore poor on the other. Where is the inclusive growth which is being talked about?"

L.K. Advani, Leader of the Opposition

"Had the Clinton administration been prepared to offer the BJP-led government the nuclear deal, the Indian side would have been astonished and gone for it."

Strobe Talbott, former US diplomat

"Mr Prime Minister, you get the (Woman's Reservation) Bill for passage and BJP will support it unconditionally."

Rajnath Singh, BJP president

"A lot of people, who can't do certain things themselves, talk. So one should let them talk. I prefer to listen to those who matter to me."

Sachin Tendulkar, cricketer

